

12 And he waited yet another seven days,
A' and he sent out the dove ;
and it did not again return to him .

- a 13 And it came about in the six hundred and first year,
b in the first month,
b' on the first of the month,
c the waters were dried up from upon the land ;
d and Noah removed the covering of the ark ,
c' and he looked, and behold, the face of the land was dried up .
b' 14 And in the second month,
b' on the twenty-seventh day of the month,
c' the land was dry .

Genesis 8:6-14. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Spying Birds in Mesopotamian Flood Accounts

The sending out of the raven and the dove is one of the most well-known parallels between the flood stories in the Epic of Gilgamesh, the account of Berossus, and the biblical account.

When the seventh day arrived,
I released **a dove** to go free,
The dove went and returned,
No landing place came to view, **it turned back**.
I released **a swallow** to go free,
The swallow went and returned,
No landing place came to view, **it turned back**.
I sent **a raven** to go free,
The raven went forth, saw the ebbing of the waters,
It ate, circled, left droppings, **did not turn back**.

Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11

After the waters of the Great Flood had come and quickly left, Xisuthrus **freed several birds**. They **found neither food nor a place to rest, and they returned** to the ship. After a few days, he again **set free some other birds**, and **they too came back** to the they ship, but **they returned with claws covered with mud**. Then later for **a third time he set free some other birds**, but **they did not return** to the ship.

Berossus' Babyloniaca, paragraph 54

It's clear that the sending out of the birds was a standard motif in the tradition used by the biblical author, who adapted this scene to his own purposes by the introduction of strategic vocabulary.

Recalling the Days of Genesis 1

The sequence of Genesis 8:1-9:6 replays the key vocabulary of the days of creation in Genesis 1.

- The repetition of “seven days” two times activates the pattern of seven days in Genesis 1.
- The dove’s return “at the time of the evening” recalls day four, when the sun and moon are appointed as rulers who divide the day from the night.
- The variety of birds recalls day five: the birds who fly above the waters.

The 3 + 1 Test of Noah

Noah first sends out a raven, an omnivorous bird and therefore ritually impure (see Lev. 11:15). It does not return to the ark, presumably because it can find food out among the waters.

Noah then sends out a dove, a vegetarian and ritually pure bird (see Lev. 1:14; 5:7), and it cannot find food until the dry land appears.

The threefold sending out of the bird is a kind of test that Noah uses to make sure the divine promise is really taking place. This makes sense of why the narrator slows down the story, unnecessarily as far as the plot is concerned, to retell the dove scene in language reminiscent of the garden of Eden test.

Genesis 8:8-11 Instructor's Translation

⁸ And he sent out a dove from him,
to see if the waters were abated (קלל) from the face of the ground.

⁹ And the dove found no place of rest for the sole of its foot,
and it returned to him into the ark,
because the waters were on the surface of all the land.

And he sent out his hand and took it (שלח + יד + לקח)

and he brought her to himself (בוא + אליו) into the ark

¹⁰ and he waited yet another seven days;
and again he sent out the dove from the ark.

¹¹ And the dove came to him at the time of evening,
and behold, in its mouth was an olive **leaf (עלה)**, freshly picked,
and Noah knew (ידע) that the waters were abated (קלל) from upon the land,

Literary Connections to the Eden Test

- קלל is a homonym for “curse,” parallel to ארר in Genesis 3:14, 17
- “**So that he doesn’t send out his hand and take (שלח + יד + לקח)** also from the tree of life” (Gen. 3:22)
- “**And he brought her to the human (בוא + אליו)**” (Gen. 2:22)
- “**And they knew (ידע)** that they were naked and they sewed a fig tree **leaf (עלה)** and made garments for themselves” (Gen. 3:7)

In Genesis 3, God is testing the humans’ faithfulness to him, while in Genesis 8, Noah is testing God’s faithfulness to him.

- God “brought the woman to the human,” and she becomes the means through which the humans fail the test of following God’s command. In the same way, the bird is Noah’s means of testing God’s promise to deliver him, so he “brings her to himself.”
- Adam and Eve “send out their hand and take” from the wrong tree, which is the object of their test. In the same way, Noah sends out his hand to take the dove, which is his way of testing God’s promise.
- The humans take the **knowing** of good and bad, **know** they are naked, and so they use a **leaf** to cover over their failure. In the same way, Noah sends out a dove as a test and the **leaf** becomes the way he **knows** that God has kept his promise.

Flood Recession = New Creation

The date of the recession of the floodwaters has been coordinated with the Torah’s chronology of creation, Passover, and the inauguration of the tabernacle.

Genesis 8:13 NASB*

Now it came about in the **six hundred and first year**, **in the beginning (בראשון)**, **on the first of the month**, the water was dried up from the earth. Then Noah removed the covering of the ark, and looked, and behold, the surface of the ground was dried up.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 1:1-2 Instructor's Translation

¹ **In the beginning (בראשית)** God created the skies and the land. ² Now the land was wild and waste and darkness was over the deep waters, but the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters ...

Exodus 12:1-2 NASB

¹ Now the LORD said to Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, ² “This month shall be **the beginning (ראשון)** of months for you; it is to be **the first month of the year** to you.

Exodus 40:1-2 NASB*

¹ Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying, ² “On the **first day of the beginning (ראשון) month** you shall set up the tabernacle of the tent of meeting.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

“According to the ... chronology the new world emerged from the flood waters on the first day of the liturgical year, the same day on which the tabernacle was set up and dedicated in the wilderness (Gen. 8:13; Exod. 40:2). It will be recalled that the first temple was also dedicated during Sukkoth, the autumnal New Year Festival (1 Kgs. 8:2, 65). We are also told that it took seven years to build which ... is related to the seven days of creation. The same dating system requires that the week of creation in Gen 1:1-2:4 be the first week of the liturgical year or, in other words, the primordial New Year Festival.”

Blenkinsopp, Joseph (1976). "The Structure of P". *Catholic Biblical Association* Vol. 38, (No. 3). 283-284.

Divine Speech Summons Noah to Leave the Ark: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:15-19

A 15 And Elohim spoke to Noah, saying,

16 “ **Go out** from the ark,

B **you and your wife**
and your sons and your sons’ wives with you.

17 **From every living thing with you**

B’ **from all flesh,**
birds and animals
and every creeper that creeps on the land,

A’ **make them go out** with you,

so they can swarm in the land
and be fruitful and multiply in the land .”

A 18 And Noah **went out** ,

B **and his sons and his wife**
and his sons’ wives with him.

19 **Every living thing,**

B’ **every creeper,**
and every bird,
everything that creeps on the land,

A’ by their families **they went out** from the ark.

Genesis 8:15-19. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

The command and fulfillment structure of this scene creates an orderly and processional feel to the exit from the ark. This description of the exit from the ark precisely matches the narrative of their entrance into the ark in 6:17-22.

Entering the Ark		Exiting the Ark	
Command	6:18-20 ¹⁸ And you will go into the ark you and your sons and your wife, and your sons' wives with you. ¹⁹ And of every living thing of all flesh, two of everything you will make go into the ark, to keep them alive with you; they shall be male and female. ²⁰ Of the birds after their kind, and of the animals after their kind, of every creeping thing of the ground after its kind, two of every kind will go to you to keep them alive.	8:15-17 ¹⁵ And Elohim spoke to Noah, saying, ¹⁶ "Go out from the ark, you and your wife and your sons and your sons' wives with you. ¹⁷ From every living thing with you from all flesh, birds and animals and every creeper on the land, make them go out with you ...	
Fulfillment	7:13-16 ¹³ On that very day Noah went and Shem and Ham and Japheth, the sons of Noah, and Noah's wife and the three wives of his sons with them, into the ark, ¹⁴ they, and every living creature after its kind, and all the beasts after their kinds, and every creeper that creeps on the land after its kind, and every bird after its kind, every bird of every wing. ¹⁵ And they went to Noah, into the ark, two by two, from all flesh in which was the breath of life, ¹⁶ and those going, male and female of all flesh ...	8:18-19 ¹⁸ And Noah went out, and his sons and his wife and his sons' wives with him. ¹⁹ Every living thing, every creeper, and every bird, everything that creeps on the land, by their families they went out from the ark.	
<i>Entering the Ark and Exiting the Ark.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).			

This elaborate emphasis on the entrance into and exit from the temple-ark gives the narrative a liturgical feel, as if we are watching a procession into and out of the temple that passes through the "gate" to experience divine presence and deliverance.